of these fighters were spread all over Pakistan. Until 2000, they kept flourishing and remained relevant in one way or the other.

Their situation completely changed when the government of Pakistan took an opposite stand on Afghan policy after the 9/11 attack on New York. The ideology of jihad, which was in vogue for more than two decades, was considered secondary. This abrupt change in policy not only stirred their ideological frame of mind but also rendered them jobless.

However, the regrouping of Al Qaeda, the resurgence of Afghan Taliban and the birth of local Taliban attracted a number of these former fighters. Their training, temperament and experience made them useful for these organisations, thereby ushering in a new and more lethal phase of extremism and terrorism.

Jihadi leaders were agitated over Musharraf's signing of the Islamabad Agreement (with the then Indian Prime Minister Vajpayee in 2004) to 'fight together against terrorism' because they viewed it as a perfidy on the part of the country's military leadership. Top jihadi leaders did not like the reducing of the Kashmiri militants to mere spectators by the Pakistani establishment under the US pressure. Many estranged jihadists joined hands with the terrorists to attack the army and law enforcement agencies (Amir Rana).

Religious extremism, sectarianism and terrorism in Pakistan can be roughly divided into four phases, culminating in the current situation:

1. formation of jihadi parties and jihad culture by Afghan jihad;
2. Indian-sponsored terrorism and sabotage in the 1980s;
3. eruption of sectarian terrorism in the early 1990s;
4. the rise of militancy after 2001 (Al Qaeda, TTP, etc.).

FIRST PHASE

The mother of all phases and faces of religious extremism and later on insurgency and terrorism in Pakistan can be attributed to the Afghan jihad that gave birth to jihadi parties and jihadi culture during and after the Afghan jihad. A number of religious and jihadi parties were formed, which recruited and despatched thousands of Pakistanis to Afghanistan. The rapid growth of jihadi, religious and sectarian parties gradually changed the sectarian and political landscape of Pakistan.